

Creative Project Abstract

Text(s): Leo Tolstoy's *The Death of Ivan Ilyich* and Charlotte Perkins Gilman's *The Yellow Wall-Paper*

Format: Faux magazine (period-style periodical spread, 1880s–1900s), featuring dual-POV diary entries

My project focuses on a pattern I see in both texts and in real life: a person suffering tries to communicate their pain, is dismissed or misunderstood by the people closest to them, withdraws into isolation as the suffering builds, and eventually reaches a breaking point — at which point, and often only then, the people around them finally register that something was wrong. In *The Yellow Wall-Paper*, the narrator repeatedly tries to tell John she is not improving and wants to leave; he dismisses her as fanciful, and she stops trying to be understood until her collapse into the wallpaper's pattern. In *The Death of Ivan Ilyich*, Ivan tries to share his fear of death with his wife, Praskovya, who barely listens; he longs to be pitied “like a sick child” but is met with denial from everyone except the servant Gerasim, until his suffering erupts into three days of continuous howling.

To dramatize this gap, I will design a faux period magazine built around two dual-POV diary features: one presenting the narrator's diary entries alongside John's, and one presenting Ivan Ilyich's entries alongside Praskovya's, each pair covering the same days from opposite perspectives. Placed side by side, the entries will let readers see the suffering person's real fear and need to be heard directly against the other's genuine but blind belief that they are being caring and attentive — exposing, without commentary, how a person's pain can go completely unseen by someone who insists they understand them.

Presenting both pairings within one issue lets the two stories comment on each other: whether confined to a nursery or to a life of decorum, the same quiet failure to listen recurs, and the same eruption is what it finally takes to be seen.